

7. Sharkara payasam

8. Black curd rice

9. Gunpowder rice idli with ghee

10. Green chilli and coconut chutney

11. Beetroot and brown rice salad with fresh coconut and raw mango and curry leaf dust

12. Black rice bhel with mango and kalonji emulsion, and pickled curd chilli

to improve their nutritional profile.

Consumers or food companies, they are all singing the same tune—how to eat right. But what exactly is eating right? Delhi-based homemaker Jaya Dasgupta, 49, a mother of three, expressed that dilemma best when she bemoaned: "The amount of information on food out there is overwhelmingly confusing. Do we eat rice, millets or wheat? Do we drink A2 milk? Do we eat ghee? Do we fast? I had to outsource my nutritional requirements to a dietitian because I couldn't make the choice myself." To address the predicament that people like Dasgupta find themselves in, INDIA TODAY spoke to a range of top nutritionists and food experts to put together this guide to eating right.

The Grain Pain

Here is something that you probably know already—Indians go overboard on carbs. And where do those carbs come from? Wheat is a major culprit. Once a staple of North Indian thalis, it has now become common across dining rooms in India. And wheat is high in gluten content, which, in some individuals, can cause serious health issues. Their bodies sense it as a toxin and generate immunity cells to attack it. Continuous consumption can trigger inflammation and damage the gastrointestinal tract. Commonly diagnosed as coeliac disease, one per cent of the Indian population reports being afflicted with it.

Other individuals may not have coeliac disease but may still be sensitive to gluten. They experience similar discomfort, bloating, diarrhoea or constipation if they gorge on grains high in gluten. Doctors call it non-coeliac gluten sensitivity. "Many people say 'we used to eat wheat all the time as a child, we can't have gluten sensitivity'. But we don't realise that the amount of gluten in the wheat grain has changed significantly," says Dr Arjun Dang, CEO of Dr Dang's Labs in Delhi. "Early wheat," explains Delhi-based nutritionist Dr Ishi Khosla, who is also the president of the Celiac Society of India, "had about three per cent gluten, but when we genetically modified a grain that already had an inflammatory compound, it went up to 30 per cent. We stood the risk of increasing its inflammatory properties, which is what has happened." The wheat species cultivated most in India today is of the *Triticum aestivum* or the bread wheat variety, rather than *T. Dicoccum* or emmer wheat variety, which is usually less processed and endowed with more fibre and less gluten than the bread wheat type.

White rice is another grain that has long been accused of being a 'bad' or 'empty' carb and has been eliminated entirely from many a no-carb diet. Current dietary wisdom is now seeking to rescue it from that ignominy, with many nutritionists recommending it as a substitute for wheat, especially for those sensitive to gluten. Moderation remains the key word, though. "If you enjoy white rice," says Neha Sahaya, a Mumbai-based clinical nutrition consultant and founder of Neha Sahaya